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What Motivates Reasoning? A Theory of Goal-Dependent Political Evaluation

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Abstract: *Rather than exhibiting bias or open-minded reasoning at baseline, we argue that information processing is motivated by whatever goals a context makes salient. Thus, if politics feels like debate, people will be motivated to argue for their side. If politics feels like deliberation, they will be motivated to seek consensus through open-minded processing. Results from three experiments demonstrate: (1) Politics evokes thoughts similar to conflictual contexts and dissimilar from deliberative contexts. (2) Consequently, information labeled "political" primes the motivation to counterargue, leading to opinion polarization. Absent such labeling, no such motivation is evident, explaining why bias is common but not inherent to politics. (3) Despite this capacity for bias, people can be motivated to actively process and accept counterattitudinal information by simply making the value of open-mindedness salient. This suggests open-minded discourse is possible even absent motivation to evaluate information accurately. We conclude by discussing the implications of our research for political discourse.*

Verification Materials: The data and materials required to verify the computational reproducibility of the results, procedures and analyses in this article are available on the American Journal of Political Science Dataverse within the Harvard Dataverse Network, at: https://doi.org/10.7910/DVN/JIFKOU.

Are citizens capable of fulfilling their role in democracy? Although research on political decision making has often pit the so-called "rational" citizen (Downs 1957) against the "rationalizing" citizen (Lodge and Taber 2013), evidence is mounting in favor of a more conditional approach to understanding the motivations underlying reasoning and behavior in politics (Bolsen, Druckman, and Cook 2014; Druckman, Peterson, and Slothuus 2013; Groenendyk 2013; Lavine, Johnston, and Steenbergen 2012; Redlawsk 2001, 2002). This broader perspective discourages researchers from characterizing citizens as merely "rational" processors, whose desire for accuracy leads them to engage in open-minded evaluation, or merely biased processors, whose need to defend prior attitudes leads them to engage in rationalization. Instead, citizens' information processing motivations are conditioned on goals. Whether an individual devotes effort to open-minded processing, biased processing (i.e., rationalization), or simply withholds processing effort, depends on the goals salient when the information is encountered.

But, while this conditional approach marks an important advance in our understanding of motivations, the most central question for political science remains unanswered: What goals are salient in the context of politics? The answer to this question, we argue, should depend on the sorts of expectations people associate with contexts deemed "political." If people associate politics with debate, then the implicit goal in contexts categorized as "political" will be to win. This entails defending one's position and counterarguing against points made

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by the other side because this is how debates are won. Conversely, if people associate politics with deliberation, then they will be more motivated to listen with an open mind and look for points of agreement, since this is how social consensus is built and maintained. From this perspective, citizens are not inherently closed-minded, nor are they inherently open-minded. Instead, information processing motivations depend on the goals made salient by the context of politics.

Through a series of experiments, we show that people associate politics with conflict. This makes politics feel more like disagreement or debate and less like deliberation, which they associate with consensus. Thus, in contexts deemed "political," people are typically motivated to fight for their side with the goal of winning the argument, rather than seeking agreement and accepting counterattitudinal information. This suggests the expectation of conflict, not the substance of politics, motivates bias. In contrast, when provided a psychological incentive to demonstrate their open-mindedness—a goal associated with the context of deliberation—we find that people are more willing to consider and accept counterattitudinal claims.

Our results have broad implications for existing literature as well as real-world politics. First, they suggest researchers may be systematically overestimating the prevalence of bias in politics by inadvertently priming the motivation to counterargue and take polarized positions. According to our findings, this is likely to be the outcome of any study that reveals its subject matter to be "political." Second, our findings show that priming the desire to demonstrate open-mindedness can motivate open-minded processing, even absent an obvious incentive for accuracy. Thus, while political conflict and division may seem inescapable (Iyengar et al., 2019), scholars may actually be underestimating citizens' capacity for healthy deliberation. Motivating citizens to come together may simply require an environment that puts them in a deliberative rather than a combative frame of mind. From how we define politics for our students, to the language we use to talk about policy, to the rules of order by which we structure formal political exchanges, subtle changes may have a substantial influence on information processing goals and the health of public discourse.

Goals and Motivations

Across the social sciences, scholars have long questioned what motivations underlie information processing and behavior. In an influential article, Kunda (1990) offers a simple and elegant theory of motivation that unifies disparate approaches. Motivations, Kunda (1990) argues, are goal-dependent. Although goals vary broadly, they can be categorized into two basic types: accuracy goals (i.e., desire to reach *accurate* conclusions) and directional goals (i.e., desire to reach *particular* conclusions). From this perspective, biases result from the salience of directional goals as opposed to accuracy goals. Thus, in addition to the *amount* of effort an individual devotes to information processing, Kunda suggests the *function* of that effort also varies.

On one hand, this theory of motivation helps to explain why people often rationalize away disagreeable information (e.g., Groenendyk 2013; Bisgaard 2015) and disregard facts that would seem to aid decision making (Gaines et al. 2007; Kahan 2013; Nyhan and Reifler 2010). In such cases, directional goals, rather than accuracy goals, are driving information processing. Thus, such individuals may not be inherently deficient in their ability to process information accurately, just insufficiently motivated.

On the other hand, this approach brings to light a theoretical dilemma that extant scholarship has not fully addressed: Will directional goals inevitably dominate? After all numerous scholars have demonstrated, both theoretically and empirically, that democracy provides citizens with little incentive to process information accurately (e.g., Lupia and McCubbins 1998). And, if directional goals are as common as many suggest (Braman and Nelson 2007; Goren 2002; Petersen et al. 2013) is there any hope for open-minded public deliberation?

This is where Kunda's theory requires additional elaboration. To answer this question, we need more than a theory of motivated reasoning; we need a theory of what motivates reasoning *in politics* (see also Leeper and Slothuus 2014). What goals are salient in this domain?

Some studies provide distressing answers (e.g., Lodge and Taber 2000, 2013; Taber and Lodge 2006; Taber, Cann, and Kucsova 2009). For example Lodge and Taber (2013) suggest that, "most citizens most of the time will be *motivated reasoners* who find it difficult if not impossible to evaluate attitude-relevant information in an evenhanded way" (Lodge and Taber 2013, 59, italics in original). Attitude formation, they theorize, is an affect-driven process that precedes evaluation. From this perspective, virtually all political reasoning is motivated by the need to justify automatic and predetermined conclusions derived from the "gut," thereby equating motivated reasoning with *biased* reasoning.

Given that democracy provides little obvious incentive for accuracy motivation (e.g., Lupia and McCubbins 1998; Caplan 2007), it is reasonable for researchers like Lodge and Taber to be pessimistic. But must reasoning *in politics* always be biased? The notion that voters are virtually incapable of engaging in open-minded evaluation, seems incompatible with the resiliency of democracy. Thus, others have sought to understand what might condition processing bias, allowing for a healthier democracy.

Among the first to take this conditional approach, Redlawsk shows, through a series of innovative studies simulating the flow of information during a real campaign, that the accuracy of voter decision making can be enhanced through experimental manipulation. When warned that they would be asked to recall information about candidates, Redlawsk's participants considered more counterattitudinal information (Redlawsk 2002), reported more accurate assessments of candidates (Redlawsk 2001), and showed a higher likelihood of voting "correctly" (Redlawsk 2001; Redlawsk 2002). In a related study, Redlawsk, Civettini, and Emmerson (2010) find a tipping point after which directionally motivated conclusions can no longer be sustained in the face of counterattitudinal information. Together, these results suggest that, under the right conditions, directionally motivated biases can be reduced, yielding more accurate political evaluations and decisions.

Nonetheless, building on Lodge and Taber (2000, 2013), Redlawsk still expects directionally motivated reasoning to constitute the default processing mode in politics, which must be turned off to achieve accuracy. Recent studies, however, suggest that both directional and accuracy motivation may be conditioned on goals. For example, studies show that polarization and opposition incivility condition processing biases, suggesting a lack of any clear motivation at baseline (Bolsen, Druckman, and Cook 2014; Druckman, Peterson, and Slothuus 2013; Druckman et al. 2019).

Building on these findings, we theorize that directional goals may be common in contexts deemed "political," and perhaps particularly common in the sorts of campaign environments examined by Redlawsk (2001); Redlawsk (2002) and Redlawsk, Civettini, and Emmerson (2010). However, democratic decision making should not be assumed to be biased at baseline. Individuals may be motivated to defend their prior opinions or accept new information, but, at baseline, we expect individuals to have little motivation to process information either way. What motivates reasoning depends on the goals salient in that context, so the critical question is, what goals are salient *in politics*?

Goal-Dependent Motivations: Deliberative versus Adversarial Contexts

To identify what sorts of goals and motivations underlie political behavior, we start by considering what it means to engage in "politics." Laswell (1936) famously defines politics as "who gets what, when, and how." This definition reflects a classic liberal perspective, characterizing politics as individualistic and inherently conflictual. From a republican perspective, however, politics is a public endeavor in which individuals come together to support the common good of the community (Rousseau 1893). Thus, politics is rooted in public consensus, not private conflict. Likewise, deliberative democracy theorists emphasize that, even if people come to the table with differing ideas and interests, public discourse and consensus-seeking must be at the center of politics (Habermas 1996). Even Arendt (2018), typically classified as an agonist, argues that it is precisely the public nature of politics that distinguishes it from the economic sphere. In contrast to the marketplace, where people engage in instrumental behavior to satisfy physical needs, political action is expressive, providing individuals with a sense of meaning and identity.

In short, the liberal conception of politics may be dominant, but it is certainly not the only lens through which politics can be viewed. Mansbridge (1983), for example, distinguishes between "adversary" and "unitary" democracy in her classic study of collective decision making. In the context of adversary democracy, politics is understood as inherently conflictual. In contrast, unitary democracy is understood as inherently cooperative and deliberative. Given these differing norms, the same behaviors that would be considered acceptable and even expected in an adversarial setting would likely seem shameful and embarrassing in the context of deliberation. Rarely do we complain that adversaries in a debate are rude if they argue or closed-minded if they maintain rigid opinions because these behaviors are expected. But in the context of deliberation, which depends on consideration of opposing viewpoints, incivility and closed-mindedness are more likely to be met with social sanctioning (Raphael and Karpowitz 2013).

What, then, motivates reasoning in politics? The answer likely depends on how one perceives their context. If a person expects disagreement and debate, they are likely to act accordingly, counterarguing against ideas that conflict with their predispositions. But, if they expect deliberation, their goals are likely to be different. We suspect casual political discussion (Mutz 2008) typically fails to reach the standards of deliberation because people tend not to expect deliberation, but rather debate. However,

when placed in an implicitly (Klar 2014) or explicitly (Barabas 2004) deliberative context, expectations shift. Here, the goal becomes, not winning, but showing open-mindedness, maintaining cordial relations, and building consensus within the group. Even if people's efforts are not accuracy-motivated, a deliberative context can motivate people to devote cognitive resources to considering the points made by the other side and integrating those ideas into their prior opinions and beliefs (Barabas 2004).[1]

Based on this goal-dependent theory of motivation, we propose three hypotheses regarding information processing in contemporary American politics. Our three experiments are each designed to test one of these hypotheses.

First, given the polarization in American politics (Iyengar et al. 2019), we expect the word "politics" to prime thoughts of adversarial rather than deliberative interactions. Therefore, we conduct an experiment that compares associations with politics to associates with potentially related words: disagreement, debate, sports, deliberation, and democracy. We track individual responses for references to adversarial versus deliberative interactions.

Hypothesis 1: Thoughts about politics will mirror those associated with disagreement, debate, and sports, while contrasting with thoughts associated with deliberation and democracy.

How do these thoughts affect information processing goals? If people associate politics with disagreement, this should trigger the motivation to fight for one's side with the goal of "winning" the debate, leading to biased reasoning. Specifically, people will devote cognitive effort to counterarguing against ideas that conflict with their prior attitudes while uncritically accepting attitude-consistent ideas. We test this hypothesis in a second experiment which manipulates participants' expectations about a series of policy statements by referring to them as potentially disagreeable information, "political" information, or simply "additional" information.

Hypothesis 2: The expectation of encountering contentious information (e.g., information described as explicitly disagreeable or merely "political") will lead people to devote effort to biased reasoning in defense of their prior opinions.

In their canonical study of motivated reasoning, Lodge and Taber instructed participant to be open-minded, yet they observed the opposite. We suggest an alternative explanation: by instructing study participants to be open-minded, Lodge and Taber inadvertently signaled that participants were about to encounter disagreeable information.[2] In our third experiment, we hope to produce the sort of open-mindedness Taber and Lodge's (2006) instruction were meant to facilitate. However, rather than instructing participants to be open-minded, as Lodge and Taber did, we provide them with a psychological incentive to be open-minded.

Hypothesis 3: Given a psychological incentive to believe they are open-minded, people will engage in open-minded evaluation of information.

To foreshadow our results, the findings of our three experiments suggest that, contrary to the assumptions often made in research on motivated reasoning in politics, bias is not inherent to the way individuals process political information. If people associate politics with disagreement and debate, biased reasoning can be triggered by telling people they are entering a "political" context. But, absent an expectation of conflict, we see little evidence of biased processing. Furthermore, if provided an incentive to prove their open-mindedness, people can actually be motivated to engage in evenhanded processing of counterattitudinal information.

These results give us hope for overcoming the polarization, gridlock, and incivility that characterize contemporary American politics. Although studies often find evidence of processing bias, this may be the product of participants' expectations about the study. The same holds true for people's expectations about discussions of government and policy. Motivations depend on goals, and goals are context-dependent. People process information differently depending on whether they expect to be entering a debate, where the goal is to win, or engaging in deliberation, where open-mindedness is rewarded in pursuit of consensus.

Study 1: Does Politics Imply Disagreement?

If biased reasoning is conditioned on the goals and incentives made salient by the information context, why do we see so much evidence of bias in studies of political reasoning? One possibility is that study participants are often made aware that they are taking part in a study of *politics*. If people associate politics with disagreement and debate, priming the expectation of "politics" may incentivize biased reasoning regardless of whether researchers attempt to encourage accuracy or impartiality.

[1]It is possible that, under the right conditions, campaigns might produce similar goals (Redlawsk 2001).

[2]See (Druckman 2012) for additional discussion.

To test our hypothesis that people associate politics with adversarial rather than deliberative interactions (Hypothesis 1), we conducted an experiment that randomly assigned a stimulus word to each participant: politics, disagreement, debate, deliberation, democracy, or sports. Participants were asked to "Please describe what comes to mind when you think of the word [treatment word]."[3] Coders unaware of the word the participant had been assigned to describe, or the hypotheses being tested, coded these open-ended responses. Three pairs of codes were constructed to capture the dimensions distinguishing these types of interactions. The first pair of codes (conflict/consensus) were designed to reflect the climate associated with the stimulus word (e.g., hostility versus harmony). The second pair of codes (competition/cooperation) were designed to reflect the behaviors associated with the stimulus word (e.g., contending against each other vs. working together). The third pair of codes (open-mindedness/closed-mindedness) were designed to reflect the sort of reasoning associated with each of the stimulus words. Although these pairs of codes were each meant to capture opposite ends of a dimension differentiating adversarial interactions from deliberative interactions, they were coded independently to avoid imposing unnecessarily restrictive assumptions a priori. Each of the six variables was coded "1" if the code fit the response and "0" if it did not (see supporting information (SI, p. 1) for coding details and intercoder reliability).

Study participants were recruited through Amazon's Mechanical Turk ($N = 370$, demographics reported in SI, p. 2). Although the sample is not representative of the population, it shows substantial demographic variability.

Results

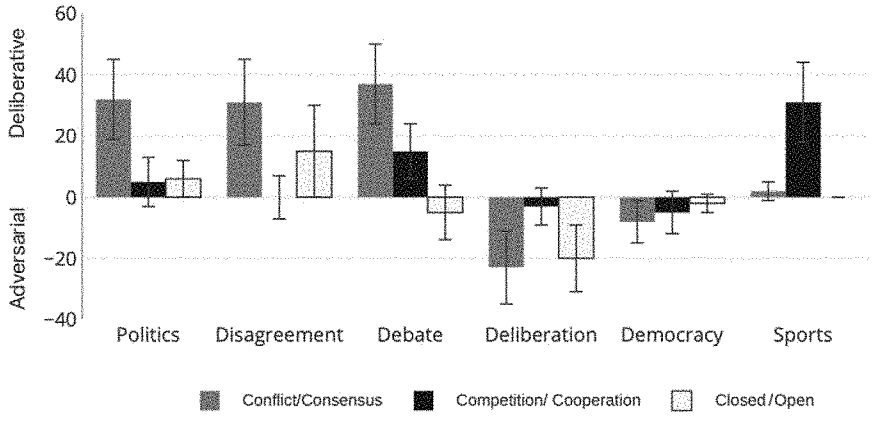
In Figure 1, each bar represents the percentage of participants whose associations were coded on the adversarial side of a given dimension (conflict, competition, and closed-mindedness) minus the percentage of participants whose associations were coded on the deliberative side of a given dimension (consensus, cooperation, and open-mindedness).

Across the experimental conditions, one can see the similarity between politics, disagreement, and debate, each of which tends to be associated with thoughts of adversarial interactions. Within each of these three groups (politics (35%), disagreement (37%), debate (41%)), thoughts of conflict are significantly more prevalent ($p <$ .01) than thoughts about consensus (politics (3%), disagreement (7%), debate (3%)).

When it comes to competition versus cooperation and open-mindedness versus closed-mindedness, the

[3]Participants were assigned to describe the thoughts they associated with only one of these words, so all comparisons occur between groups.

FIGURE 1 Respondent Associations with Politics Versus Other Terms



Note: Participants were significantly more likely to associate politics with conflict than consensus ($p <.01$) and closed-minded than open-mindedness ($p>.05$). They appeared more likely to associate politics with competition than cooperation, but this difference is not significant ($p = .24$). The pattern of thought associated with politics is similar to the pattern associated with disagreement and debate and dissimilar to the pattern associated with deliberation, democracy, and sports.

adversarial associations remain clear, but we see some differences. Participants in the politics condition show a slightly, but not significantly higher ($p = .24$), tendency to mention ideas related to competition (8%) than cooperation (3%), and a small tendency to mention thoughts associated with closed-mindedness (6%) compared to open-mindedness (0%) ($p < .05$). In comparison to politics, disagreement is more likely to arouse thoughts related to closed-mindedness (19%), and debate is slightly more likely to arouse thoughts related to open-mindedness (8%) ($p < .05$).

Turning to the other conditions, politics shows a clear contrast with deliberation and democracy. Deliberation and democracy are significantly more likely to evoke thoughts of consensus (deliberation (28%), democracy (8%)) compared to thoughts of conflict (deliberation (5%), democracy (0%)) ($p < .05$). Compared to politics, deliberation was also significantly more likely to evoke thoughts related to open-mindedness (22%) ($p < .01$), and democracy was significantly less likely to arouse thoughts related to closed-mindedness (0%) ($p < .05$). Given that our system of politics is a democracy, this contrast is notable. It appears that the participants in our study have a liberal understanding of politics, coupled with a rather republican understanding of democracy.

Finally, in partial contrast to expectations, the sports condition stands out from all the others. Most notably, while politics is associated strongly with conflict (35%) and only relatively weakly with competition (8%), sports is associated closely with competition (38%) and not at all closely with conflict (2%). This mirrors the distinction theorists have drawn between agonism and antagonism (Mouffe 2009), suggesting that politics fails to live up to expectations agonists have for the political sphere (Arendt 2018). Sports feel like good-natured competition (i.e., agonism), while politics feels like a fight between enemies (i.e., antagonism).

Study 2: Political Goals and Bias

Although political bias may appear to be all around us, it can be difficult to discern what motivates reasoning. When individuals reject arguments (Lodge and Taber 2013; Taber and Lodge 2006) and evidence (Gaines et al. 2007; Nyhan and Reifler 2010) that conflicts with their prior opinions, it may be that their priors are strong and well informed, not that they are engaging in biased reasoning (Bullock 2009; Gerber and Green 1999). After all, if a person's opinion is informed by substantial evidence, why should she be swayed by a single piece of contrary information?

So, how can we determine whether biased reasoning is occurring? Taber and Lodge (2006) and Lodge and Taber (2013) compare people with strong priors to people with weak priors, showing that individuals who initially support a policy rate arguments incongruent with their opinion as weaker relative to congruent arguments, take longer to think about incongruent arguments, and eventually report more polarized opinions than they had when the study began.

Although Taber and Lodge make a compelling case for their interpretation of these results as evidence of biased reasoning, it stands to reason that individuals with strong priors would rationally counterargue against incongruent arguments because they honestly doubt the validity of those arguments. Given this criticism, a stronger case for biased reasoning requires controlled comparison. This also provides an opportunity to test the conditionality of bias and determine whether it serves as the baseline mode of processing, as the researchers suggest, or whether policy information can be conveyed without triggering such motivations. This is our strategy in Study 2.

Study Design

The results from Study 1 hint that the word "politics" provides individuals with an important contextual cue: this is the time for arguments and debate. In Study 2, we test our prediction that context shapes goals, and goals motivate reasoning (Hypothesis 2). Study participants were members of the Survey Sampling International (SSI) (Now Dynata) panel ($N = 647$).[4] Sample details, measures, and randomization checks are in SI (pp. 2–4).

Our test relies, in part, on the methods of Taber and Lodge's (2006) canonical motivated reasoning study, in which study participants were asked to evaluate policy statements.[5] Prior to reading these statements, Taber and Lodge's participants received the following instructions meant to make the test more conservative:

> PLEASE NOTE: We want to know how WEAK or STRONG you believe the argument is, NOT WHETHER YOU AGREE OR DISAGREE

[4]SSI (rebranded as Dynata) uses its panel to produce samples that are nationally representative, though nonprobability. Additional participants completed the study, but we exclude people who took no position on affirmative action, leaving $N = 647$.

[5]We focus on Taber and Lodge (2006), since they have been credited with helping to foster the emergence of motivated reasoning research in the discipline (see Druckman, Kuklinski, and Sigelman 2009).

> WITH THE ARGUMENT. Please try to leave your feelings about [affirmative action/gun control] aside and indicate how strong or weak you feel the argument is. Please be as objective as possible.

Given our goal-dependent theory of motivated reasoning, we suspect that, by classifying the information as "arguments," these instructions prepared participants to argue. And, by entreating participants to leave their "feelings aside" and "be as objective as possible," Taber and Lodge (2006) unintentionally primed participants to prepare for conflict. In short, we suspect that, as is often the case in politics, these instructions signaled participants to be ready for a fight, thereby promoting biased processing.[6] To test this possibility, we manipulated the instructions provided in our study.

Participants were randomly assigned to one of three groups. In the first group, participants were told that they would receive some "additional information." In the second group, they were told that they would receive some "political information," which we expected to signal disagreement. In the third group, we explicitly told participants that they would receive information that might "contain some opinions and ideas with which you disagree." All instructions had parallel sentence structure. In our discussion we refer to the first group (additional information) as the control condition and the two treatments as (1) the "political" condition, and (2) the "disagreement" condition.

Following the instructions, participants were exposed to two statements against affirmative action and two statements supporting affirmative action. This means that supporters and opponents of affirmative action each received statements that were congruent and incongruent with their prior opinions. All statements were taken directly from Taber and Lodge (2006) (see SI, p. 2).

Measures

Our measures follow Taber and Lodge (2006). First, we asked participants to rate the strength of the affirmative action statements, using a 1 (very weak) to 10 (very strong) scale. Second, Taber and Lodge (2006) write that the time a person spends reading a statement can be used as a proxy for counterarguing. We follow the original study, also considering the time participants took to read statements. Third, we measure participants' posttreatment positions, as Taber and Lodge suggest counterarguing should lead to opinion polarization (although see Guess and Coppock 2020; Wood and Porter 2019, for important rejoinders). Finally, Taber and Lodge (2006) hypothesize that biased reasoning should be more likely among sophisticates and those with stronger attitudes, which we also test. Thus, our measures largely replicate those of Taber and Lodge (2006), but see SI (pp. 2, 13) for a more detailed comparison.

Results

We analyze three main outcomes: (1) ratings of statement strength, (2) the time it took participants to read and evaluate these statements (a proxy for counterarguing effort), and (3) posttreatment positions on affirmative action. If our expectations hold, compared to the control condition, we should see more evidence of biased reasoning when participants are primed to expect conflict. The disagreement condition manipulates this expectation explicitly. The political condition does so indirectly, building on the association between politics and conflict established in Study 1.[7]

Statement Ratings. We begin with participants' ratings of the affirmative action statements. Like Taber and Lodge (2006), we compare the ratings of (pretreatment) supporters to opponents of affirmative action. More specifically, the bars in Figure 2 represent the polarization of ratings: the average ratings given to statements by participants who support affirmative action minus the average rating given to the statements by a participant who opposes affirmative action.[8] Thus, bars for the pro-affirmative action statements should be positive (Figure 2a), while bars for the anti-affirmative action statements should be negative (Figure 2b). We estimate the effect of our experimental conditions on this polarization using OLS regression with interactions between pretreatment support versus opposition and treatment dummies. All strength ratings are rescaled 0–1, where 0 means a very weak statement and 1 means a very strong statement.

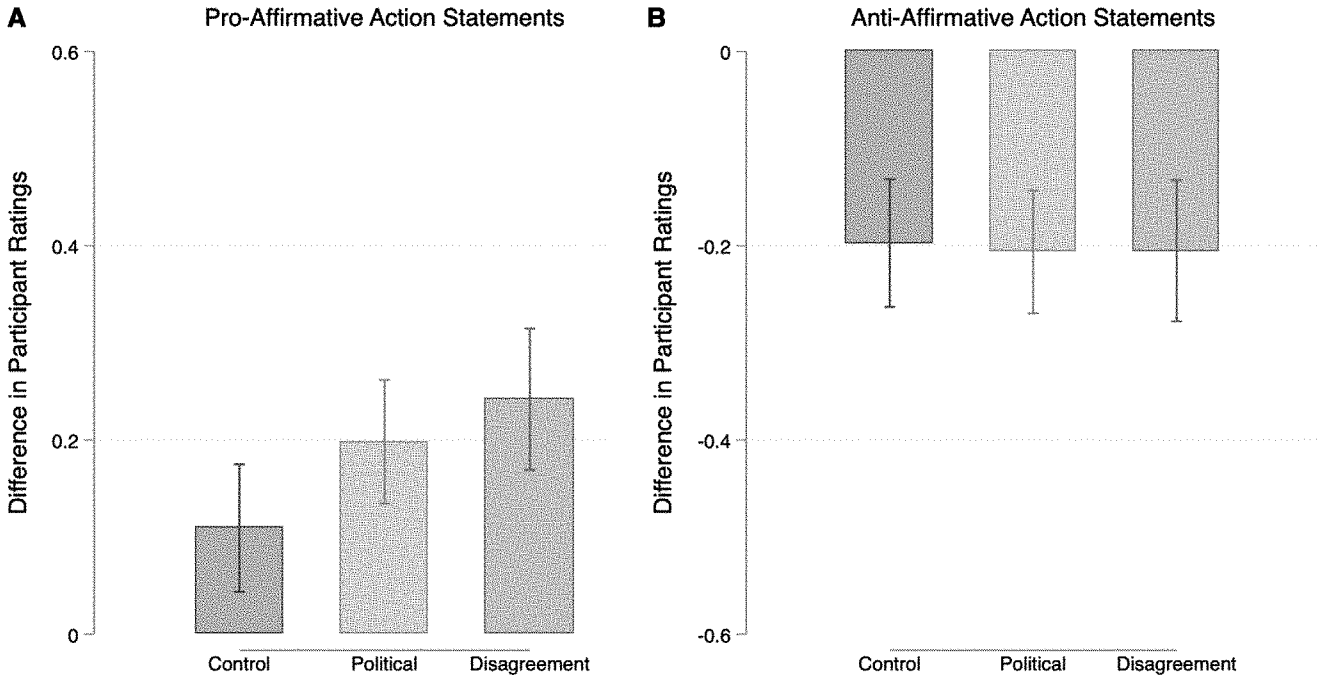
As one would expect, results show that supporters of affirmative action generally give stronger ratings to statements that support affirmative action, while opponents give stronger ratings to the opposing statements.

[6]Druckman (2012) also theorizes indirectly about this possibility, though does not test it empirically.

[7]We have no a priori expectation regarding the relative effect sizes in the two treatment conditions.

[8]Following previous research, we exclude participants who took neutral positions on our measure.

FIGURE 2 Difference in Ratings of Affirmative Action Statements by Condition (Study 2)



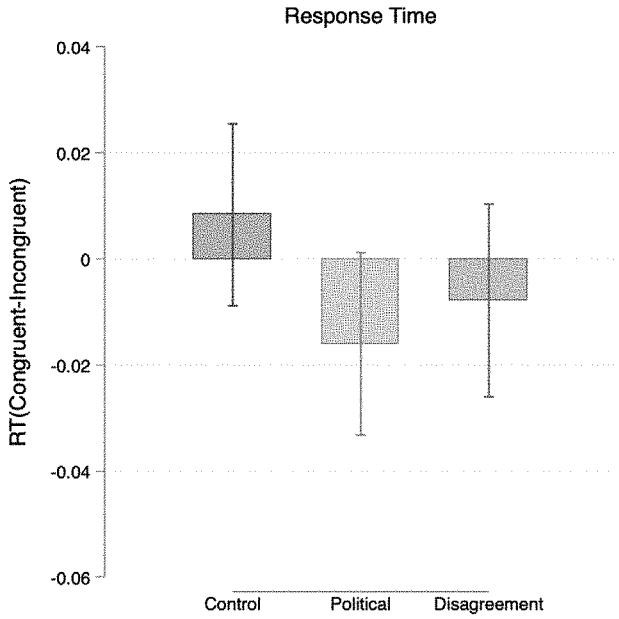
Note: Bars represent statement ratings by supporters minus ratings by opponents. Positive bars in subpart 2a represent higher ratings of pro-statements by supporters, and negative bars in subpart 2b represent higher ratings of anti-statements by opponents. All differences between supporters and opponents reach statistical significance ($p < .0001$). In subpart 2a, the difference between disagreement and control is 0.13, $p = .008$, two-tailed, and the difference between political and control is 0.09, $p = .053$, two-tailed. There is no statistically significant difference between the political and disagreement conditions. In subpart 2b, differences do not reach statistical significance. Coefficients are in SI (p. 4).

We also see evidence that the amount of polarization depends on the manipulated instructions—although most clearly when participants are rating statements in support of affirmative action. Here, compared to the control condition, both the political and disagreement conditions show greater polarization in statement ratings. Although the effects are most pronounced in the condition cueing disagreement most directly, the difference in ratings increases in the "political" condition where participants had to infer for themselves that this signaled disagreement (as Study 1 suggests). We note that, for anti-affirmative action statements, we do not observe the same clear patterns, due primarily to the higher level of polarization observed for anti-affirmative action statements in the control group. We speculate that this higher base rate may have resulted from the negativity of the anti-affirmative action statements, which in contrast to the pro-affirmative action statements, could have signaled conflict across conditions.

Since Taber and Lodge (2006) argue that processing biases should be most prevalent among people with strong attitudes and high political sophisticated, we test our predictions within each of these subgroups (SI, p. 5). Among those with strong attitudes, we again see the strongest treatment effects for the pro-affirmative action statements, but we see significant effects for both sets of statements among those with higher levels of sophistication. For this group, the political and the disagreement conditions lead to ratings polarization. Thus, even among the participants who should be most biased, according to Taber and Lodge, we see evidence of conditionality.

Response Time. Research on motivated reasoning shows that people devote effort to counterarguing against counterattitudinal information, while uncritically accepting attitude congruent statements. This results in comparatively more time spent processing counterattitudinal information (see Redlawsk 2001; Taber and Lodge 2006). Therefore, we next examine the amount of time taken by participants to consider statements congruent with their prior opinions on affirmative action relative to the time they spent considering incongruent statements. Positive values (max = 1) indicate greater attention to congruent statements and negative values indicate greater attention to incongruent statements

FIGURE 3 Responses Times (Study 2)



Note: Bars reflect difference in times for statements incongruent with prior opinions compared to statements congruent with prior opinions; outliers were removed. The difference between control and political is -0.024, $p = .049$, two-tailed. The difference between control and disagreement is -0.016, $p = .20$, two-tailed. The difference between the disagreement and political conditions is not significant. Coefficients are in SI (p. 7).

(max $= -1$), thus only negative values are consistent with previous studies.[9]

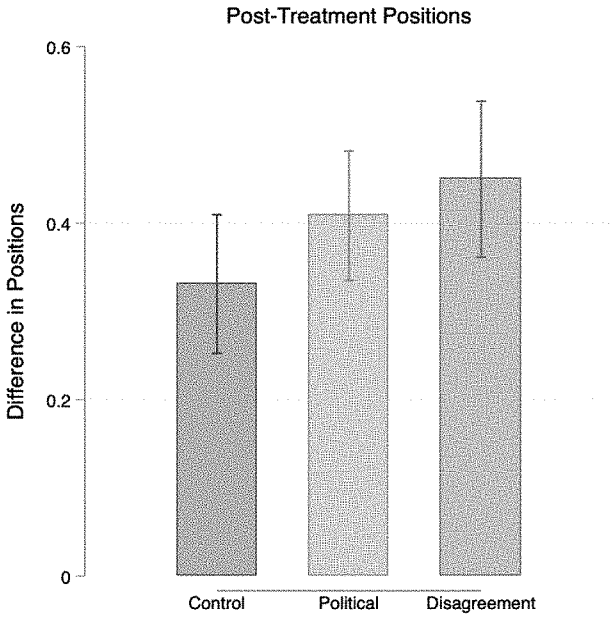
Our findings (Figure 3) again suggest that biased processing occurs when people expect conflict. We observe no significant difference between time spent considering congruent versus incongruent statements in our control group. If anything, participants spent slightly longer on congruent statements. However, participants assigned to the political and disagreement conditions spent more time reading and evaluating attitudinally incongruent statements. Thus, we observe the same pattern identified as biased reasoning by Taber and Lodge (2006), but *only* in our treatment conditions.

When we compare differences in response times between conditions, we find a significant difference between the control and political condition ($p < .05$), but we note the difference between the control and disagreement condition does not reach the conventional threshold for significance.[10] Regardless, the fact that participants spent significantly more time on incongruent statements suggests that processing biases are likely conditioned on the salience of relevant goals (e.g., winning the debate).

Posttreatment Polarization. As a final step, we examine participants' opinions on affirmative action posttreatment. Taber and Lodge (2006) found that, after counterarguing against counterattitudinal statements and uncritically accepting attitudinally consistent statements, study participants were more polarized (although see rejoinders by Guess and Coppock 2020, and Wood and Porter 2019). Figure 4 shows the polarization level in posttreatment positions by treatment, where higher bars represent more polarization.

Looking first at the control group, it is clear that, despite exposure to both pro-affirmative action and anti-affirmative action statement, the opinions of supporters and opponents continue to differ from pre to post. This is no surprise. Much more interesting is the fact that this difference is larger in the politics and disagreement conditions compared to the control group. This supports our

FIGURE 4 Posttreatment Polarization in Affirmative Action Positions (Study 2)



Note: Bars represent the polarization in positions of supporters and opponents. The difference between control and disagreement is $p = .045$, two-tailed and control and politics is $p = .16$, two-tailed. The difference between political and disagreement is $p = .90$, two-tailed. Coefficients are in SI (p. 7).

[9]Outliers were removed; response times were logged to comply with standard procedure.

[10]This may be attributable to the noisiness of the measures. Taber and Lodge (2006) note that time differences were not always significant.

hypothesis that the bias observed by Taber and Lodge (2006) is conditioned on the expectation of conflict.[11]

Robustness Tests with a Different Sample. In addition to our presented findings, we obtain similar results in two additional studies. These studies allow us to ensure that our results are replicable across samples (in this case to undergraduates, akin to Taber and Lodge's 2006 original study) and policy domains (in this case gun control, again replicating Taber and Lodge's original study). These studies also include a thought-listing task to measure cognitive engagement—a component of the Taber and Lodge study absent from Study 2. In each case, instructing participants that they would receive "political" statements increased evidence of biased reasoning. We present these results in SI (pp. 9–12).

Study 3: Priming the Goal of Open-Mindedness

We have shown that people can be motivated to devote effort to biased processing by priming the expectation of conflict. But when might they engage in open-minded processing? Kunda's (1990) theory makes clear that the absence of directional motivation does not connote the presence of accuracy motivation. Thus, at baseline, individuals should not be expected to engage in open-minded reasoning. Rather, they should be expected to devote minimal effort to processing information, allowing it to pass by without much consideration. This is consistent with what we observed in the Study 2 control group.

Effortful processing, whether biased or open-minded, is motivated by some goal. Often, scholars assume individuals consider all available information in order to secure favorable policies. Unfortunately, as we have discussed, democracy provides individuals with little incentive to expend this sort of effort (Downs 1957), especially when it means accepting ideas that one would prefer to reject (Caplan 2007; Groenendyk 2013; Lavine, Johnston, and Steenbergen 2012). Thus, we turn our attention away from accuracy motivation and investigate whether individuals might be motivated to demonstrate their open-mindedness as a goal in-and-of itself. In other words, might open-mindedness serve an expressive purpose, not merely an instrumental purpose?

Politics often feels like debate, leading to biased reasoning, but what if politics felt more like deliberation? We suspect people would be motivated to process information more evenhandedly, not necessarily with the goal of reaching accurate assessments, but to demonstrate their open-mindedness and thus receive rewards for conforming to deliberative norms (Groenendyk 2013; Mullinix 2018).

In contrast to Study 2, which was designed to trigger processing bias by priming the goal of "winning" the debate, our third study was designed to test our hypothesis that people can be motivated to pursue open-mindedness as a goal (Hypothesis 3). This experiment was conducted with a national sample of adult Americans collected through SSI in two waves ($N = 593$). Of the participants who completed wave 1, 65.5% of participants agreed to take part in wave 2.[12]

Study Design

Our design builds on an experiment conducted by Kunda and Sanitioso (1989) in which participants were asked to consider results from a fictitious study (although participants did not know it was fictitious) linking either introversion or extroversion to academic success. Then, participants were asked to explain why this might be true, thereby reinforcing the power of the stimulus. Participants who were told "introversion leads to success" came to view themselves as relatively more introverted, and participants who were told "extroversion leads to success" came to view themselves as relatively more extroverted.

Building on this idea, Study 3 manipulated participants' incentive to demonstrate open-mindedness. Those randomly assigned to the treatment condition received results from a fictitious study linking "life success" to the trait of open-mindedness. To ensure that the notion of "life success" would appeal to people with different sorts of priorities, the fictitious study operationalized life success in terms of marital success, income, and IQ. In addition to describing the results of the study in words, participants viewed a bar graph illustrating the difference between closed-minded people and open-minded people on the three dimensions of life success. Like Kunda and Sanitioso (1989), we then asked study participants to explain why this might be true. Of those assigned to the treatment condition, 80% generated a theory for why one might expect open-mindedness to lead to life

[11] Since participants were not exposed to policy information about gun control in Study 2, we examine gun control attitudes as a placebo test in SI (p. 8).

[12] We include a check to ensure there were no systematic factors that led participants not to complete wave 2 (SI, p. 16).

success, suggesting they accepted the purported link.[13] Those assigned to the control group received no information about the open-mindedness study and moved directly to the questionnaire. Random assignment took place in wave 2.

The first wave of our study contained questions about participants' issue positions and demographics. The second wave took place one week after the first wave was completed. This time, participants were asked to evaluate Taber and Lodge's (2006) gun control statements. Like the previous study, we tracked the amount of time participants took to evaluate these statements and measured posttreatment gun control opinion. Unlike Study 2, which included a limited battery of affirmative action statements, this study included the full battery of the Taber and Lodge (2006) gun control statements. This allowed us to leverage variability in the quality of arguments for and against gun control to test whether the open-mindedness treatment improved study participants' ability to assess quality.

Although our treatment was designed to prime open-mindedness as a goal unto itself, providing no reward for increased accuracy, it is possible that this open-mindedness might nonetheless have increased the quality of people's evaluations, improving their ability to distinguish objectively weak from objectively strong arguments. On the other hand, with only an incentive to show open-mindedness and not to reach an accurate evaluation, it seems more likely to have motivated study participants to show openness to all counterattitudinal information without distinguishing between objectively strong versus weak arguments (also see Kruglanski and Boyatzi 2012). Our final test examines this important distinction and discusses the normative implications of the results.

Results

We again examine the effect of the treatment on three outcome variables: (1) argument strength assessments, (2) the time participants spent reading and evaluating the statements, and (3) posttreatment positions. However, in contrast to Study 2, we expect this experimental treatment to increase the effort participants devote to open-minded processing. To ensure that we were not simply setting up a "straw man" to be knocked down, we excluded participants who expressed weak or ambivalent attitudes on gun control in wave 1, restricting our analyses to the top two-thirds in attitude strength. According to Lodge and Taber (2013), it is the affect underlying these individuals' strong attitudes that should automatically and unconsciously bias reasoning, making it "difficult if not impossible to evaluate attitude-relevant information in an evenhanded way" (p. 59). Thus, we attempt to give the bias Lodge and Taber (2013) predict the best possible chance to show through.[14]

From a theoretical standpoint, this makes our test more conservative. In practice, as we will discuss below, it increases baseline resistance to counterattitudinal information, giving our open-mindedness treatment something to overcome. Absent an expectation of conflict, those with weak or ambivalent attitudes were so receptive to counterattitudinal information that it created a ceiling effect. The results for the full sample are presented in SI (p. 19).

Statement Ratings. For the sake of consistency, we begin by replicating the statement strength analyses we used in Study 2. Specifically, we measure the polarization between (wave 1) supporters' and opponents' assessments of pro-gun control and anti-gun control statements. We expect to see increased open-mindedness in the treatment condition. Results in Figure 5a and b conform to the predicted pattern. Compared to the control group, random assignment to the open-mindedness condition appears to have reduced the polarization of pro-gun control and anti-gun control statement ratings. But the results only reach marginal significance ($p < .10$) for anti-gun control statements and fail to reach significance for the pro-gun control statements.

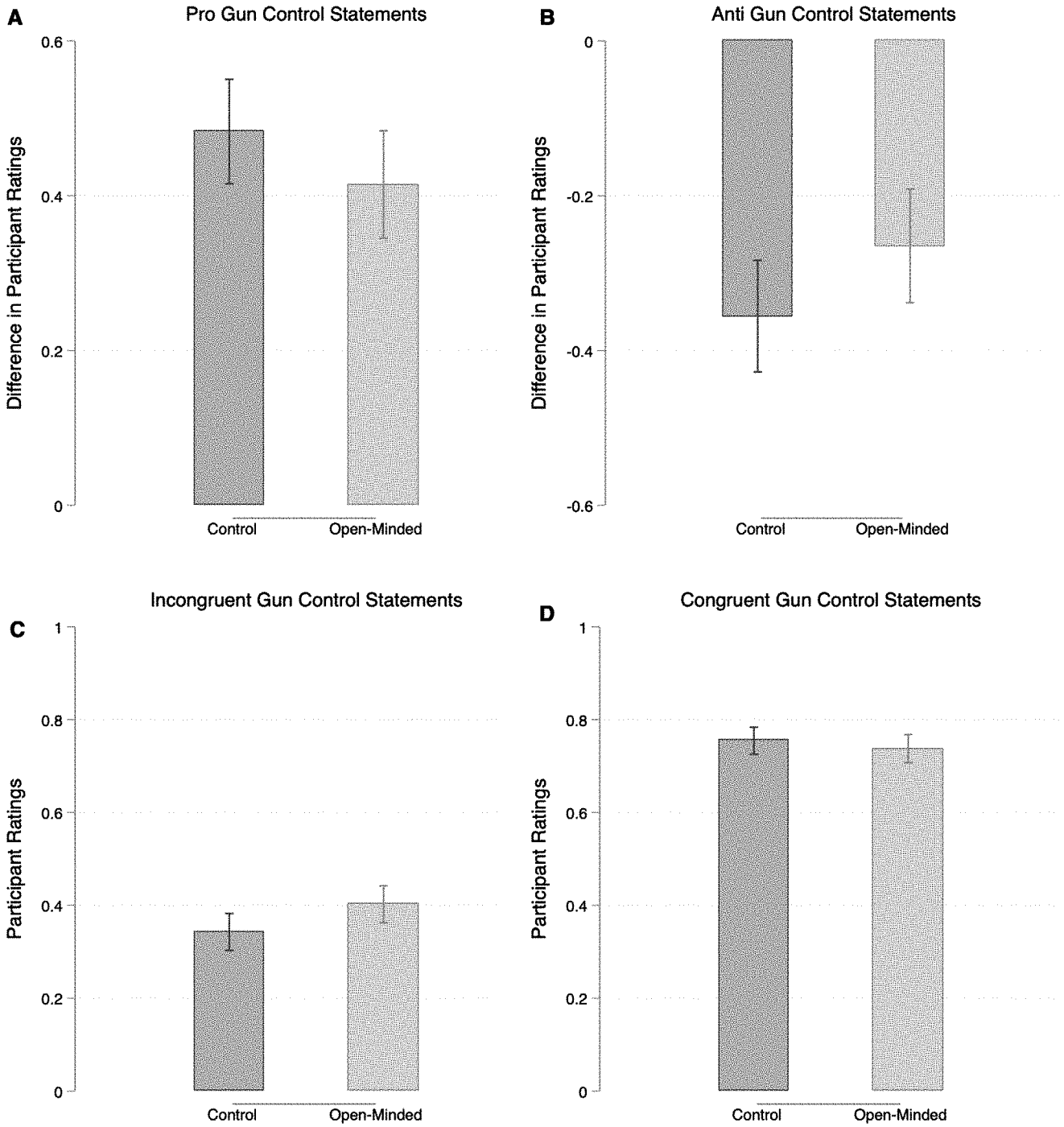
Of course, our treatment was designed to motivate open-mindedness, and open-mindedness is expressed when evaluating points made by the other side, not one's own side. Therefore, a more appropriate test of Hypothesis 3 distinguishes between pro-attitudinal and counterattitudinal statements. Thus, we recoded the evaluations of pro-gun control and anti-gun control statement so that they corresponded to (wave 1) support versus opposition, creating variables reflecting attitudinal congruency and incongruency.

As expected, Figure 5c and d shows clearer results. While there is some evidence of reduced polarization in evaluations of both types of statements, the effect is larger and statistically significant for counterattitudinal statements (Figure 5c, $p < .05$) compared to pro-attitudinal

[13] Of the remaining participants, most offered no explanation, a small percentage could not explain the relationship, and a few expressed skepticism. We replicate our results after excluding these individuals from our analyses (SI, p. 18). Results remain nearly identical.

[14] This resistance may be attributable to directionally motivated reasoning or Bayesian reasoning from a strong prior, or both.

FIGURE 5 (De)Polarization of Ratings of Gun Control Statements by Condition (Study 3)



Note: In subparts 5a and 5b, bars represent polarization in statement ratings between supporters and opponents. Positive bars in subpart 5a represent higher ratings of pro-statements by supporters, and negative bars in subpart 5b represent higher ratings by opponents. In subpart 5a, the difference between control and open-minded is -0.07, $p = .17$. In subpart 5b the difference is 0.09, $p = .08$. Within group rating differences all reach significance at $p < .001$. In subpart 5c, bars represent ratings *only* of incongruent statements; subpart 5d are ratings *only* of congruent statements. In subpart 5c, the difference between groups is 0.06, $p = .04$; in subpart 5d it is -0.02, $p = .43$. Coefficients are in SI (p. 16).

statements (Figure 5d, $p = .43$). This pattern suggests that the treatment motivated participants to show open-mindedness toward the other side, although not necessarily to reach more accurate evaluations across the board. We will return to this discussion of accuracy versus open-mindedness when we consider the underlying mechanism more directly.

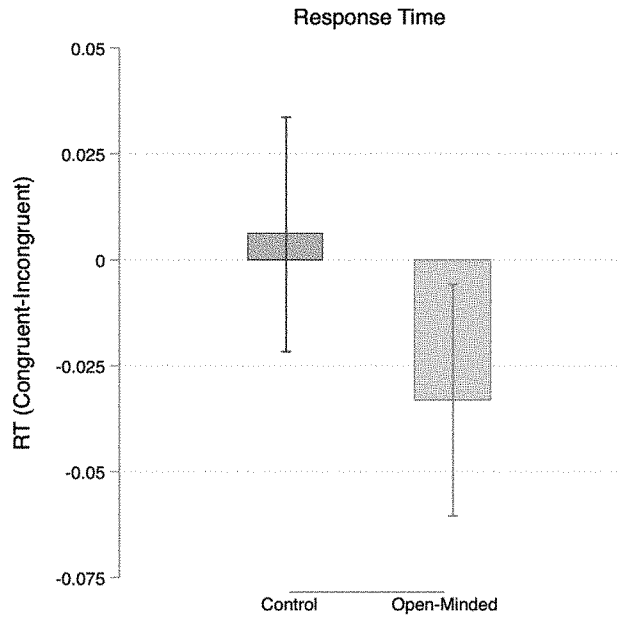
Response Time. We next examine the amount of time taken by participants to read and assess the strength of pro-attitudinal versus counterattitudinal gun control statements. Again, this measurement strategy follows directly from the existing literature (Redlawsk 2002; Taber and Lodge 2006). By subtracting time associated with incongruent responses from congruent response, we are able to difference out fixed respondent effects (e.g., reading speed, distractions in the room, response mode, etc.) Positive values (max = 1) indicate greater attention to congruent arguments, whereas negative values indicate greater attention to incongruent arguments (max = −1).

In the original study from which these statements were taken, Taber and Lodge (2006) found that participants took longer to evaluate incongruent arguments relative to congruent arguments, which they theorized was evidence of counterarguing. In Study 2, we found that this result was conditioned on priming the expectation of conflict. Specifically, we observed the pattern predicted by Taber and Lodge (2006) in our treatment conditions, but we saw no significant difference between attention paid to congruent versus incongruent statements in our control group (which did not receive a conflict prime in the instructions).

We expect to observe a similar result in the control group of this study. Absent any salient processing goal (i.e., motivation to defend their prior or to show their open-mindedness) participants should pay roughly equal attention to both sides of the gun control debate. In our treatment condition, we expect participants to devote effort to open-minded processing. Thus, we again expect participants to spend more time thinking about statements incongruent with their opinion. But, in this case, we expect this to occur not because they are counterarguing, *but because they are taking that information into open-minded consideration.*

Results presented in Figure 6 confirm our predictions. Participants in the control group spent no more time considering statements that were incongruent with their opinions than they spent considering statements that were congruent with their prior opinions ($p = .64$), replicating the pattern in Study 2. Thus, Lodge and Taber's (2013) prediction of automatic bias was again unsupported. However, those primed with the goal of open-mindedness did spend significantly more time considering statements incongruent with their predispositions ($p < .05$). And, this effect is significantly different from the null result obtained in the control group. Coupled with the fact that treatment exposure also led people to rate these incongruent statements as stronger (Figure 5c), we see a clear pattern emerging: Those assigned to the open-mindedness treatment group devoted their attention to incongruent statements, not in an effort to counterargue (as Taber and Lodge 2006 would predict), but to show their open-mindedness toward the other side.

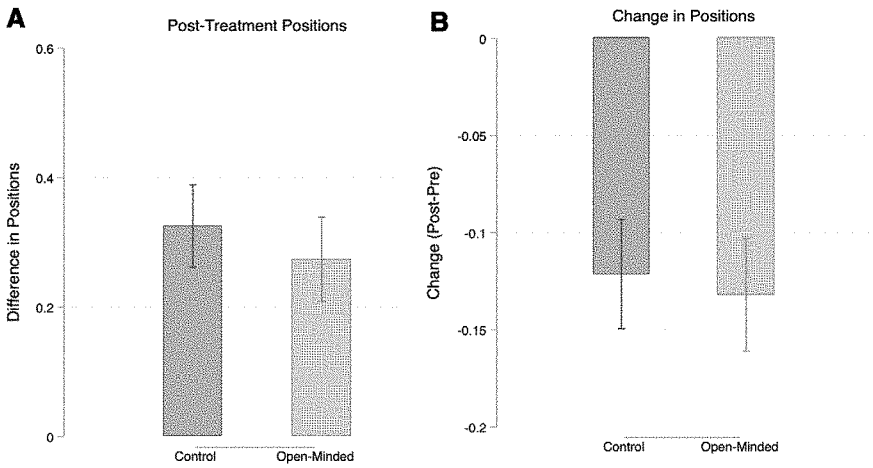
FIGURE 6 Response Times (Study 3)



Note: Bars reflect difference in average logged response times for statements incongruent with prior opinions compared to statements congruent with prior opinions. The difference in time spent in the control group is $p = .64$, while the difference in the open-minded group is $p < .05$. The difference between groups is −0.04, $p = .05$. Coefficients are in SI (p. 16).

Posttreatment Polarization. Finally, we turn to posttreatment opinions. We begin this set of analyses by again replicating the test performed in our previous experiment. Results presented in Figure 7a show the amount of polarization in posttreatment opinions between (pretreatment) gun control supporters and opponents. As predicted, we see a bit less evidence of opinion polarization in the open-mindedness treatment condition compared to the control group. However, this polarization reduction effect does not reach statistical significance.

FIGURE 7 Posttreatment Variation in Gun Control Positions (Study 3)



Note: Bars in subpart 7a represent differences between the average opinions of gun control supporters and opponents. Difference is -0.05, $p = .27$. Bars in subpart 7b represent changes in gun control opinions from pre to post, difference is -0.01, $p = .6$. Negative bars reflect opinion moderation. Coefficients are in SI (p. 16).

Given the clear pattern of increased attention to, and stronger ratings of, attitudinally incongruent statements resulting from treatment exposure in the previous two tests, this rather small and nonsignificant posttreatment opinion effect may be somewhat surprising. Were those in the treatment condition considering arguments more carefully, but then failing to follow through and update their opinions (e.g., Bisgaard 2015; Groenendyk 2013)? Since this study contained the same gun control opinion measures pre- and post-treatment, we were able to analyze within-participant opinion change in addition to polarization between respondents.

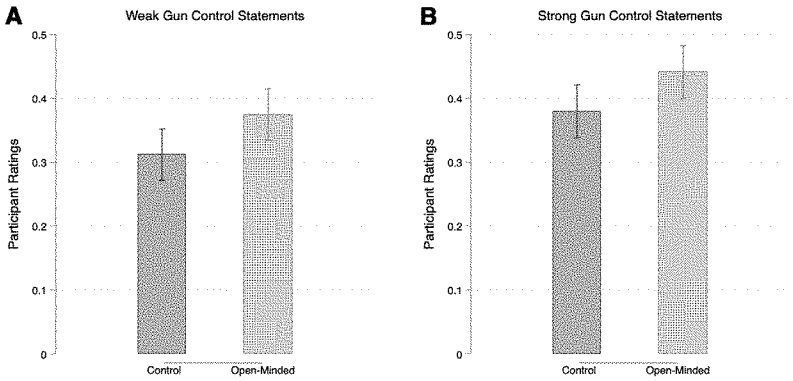
Figure 7b reveals a notable pattern. Both bars in the figure point in a negative direction, and both are significantly different from zero ($p < .01$). Thus, rather than expressing more polarized opinions in response to pro- and anti-gun control arguments, as others have found, participants across conditions *moderated* their opinions from pre to post. Recall that neither condition in this study contained anything to prime the sorts of directional goals that led to biased evaluation and opinion polarization in our last experiment. Thus, absent such a goal, even those with strong opinions seem quite willing to consider and even internalize arguments made by the other side.[15] This pattern is consistent with recent studies in which Taber and Lodge's (2006) observed pattern of opinion polarization in response to incongruent information did not replicate (Guess and Coppock 2020; Wood and Porter 2019).

Since, even in our control group, we see no evidence of opinion polarization from pre to post, it becomes clear why we did not see significant evidence of *de*polarization of posttreatment opinions in our prior analysis: There simply was no polarization effect for our open-mindedness manipulation to overcome. Rather, our within-subjects analysis shows moderation across the board. Nonetheless, despite how conservative this makes our test, it is worth noting that we do see a nonsignificant increase in opinion change (toward moderation) in our open-mindedness condition.

Additionally, as we show in SI (p. 17), this opinion change effect, as well as the between-subject depolarization effect, is actually significant among gun control opponents ($p < .05$). Although this asymmetry was certainly not predicted, it appears that, compared to supporters, opponents of gun control were more resistant to opinion change in the control group. This gave our open-mindedness treatment something to overcome,

[15]We have tried to subject our expectations to a conservative test by restricting our analyses to those who should be most likely to show evidence of directional bias (i.e., those whose initial opinions on gun control fell in the top two thirds of the sample). However, readers may wonder whether the observed pattern is merely regression to the mean. To address this concern, we analyzed the full sample, finding the same pattern of results. We have also replicated our analyses using Taber and Lodge's (2006) method: testing their polarization hypothesis by regressing posttest opinions on pretest opinions. When we replicate this test on our data (combined conditions), we get a coefficient that suggests depolarization ($B = .588$, $SE = .035$, $p < .001$).

FIGURE 8 (De)Polarization of Ratings of Attitudinally Incongruent Weak Versus Strong Gun Control Statements by Condition (Study 3)



Note: Statements were placed in strong versus weak categories based on ratings of participants with congruent attitudes. Positive bars represent higher ratings of these statements by individuals with incongruent attitudes. In subpart 8a, the difference is 0.063, $p = .03$; in subpart 8b, the difference is 0.061, $p = .04$. Coefficients are in SI (p. 18).

preventing the ceiling effect we observed in the full sample.[16]

Testing the Mechanism. As we noted earlier, we believe there is a subtle but important theoretical distinction between the motivation to show open-mindedness and the motivation to reach an accurate assessment. Open-mindedness in service to accuracy motivation is instrumental—typically a means to obtain favorable policy outcomes. But, as we have pointed out, both theory and evidence suggest democracy provides individuals little incentive to devote effort to this cause (Caplan 2007; Groenendyk 2013; Lavine, Johnston, and Steenbergen 2012). Thus, participants in our study were provided a psychological incentive to want to prove their open-mindedness as an *end in-and-of itself.*

To illustrate this subtle but critical distinction, we compare the effect of the open-mindedness treatment on people's ratings of strong versus weak counterattitudinal statements. If the open-mindedness treatment induced accuracy motivation, treatment participants' ratings of counterattitudinal statements should come to reflect the objective strength or weakness of those statements. In other words, the observed increase in cognitive effort should pay off in more *accurate* assessments. But, if the open-mindedness treatment simply induced the desire to prove one's open-mindedness, we should see the same effect between study participants' ratings of strong versus weak statements.

As an indicator of a statement's objective strength, we assessed study participants' ratings of statements *consistent* with their pretreatment opinions. We assume that, if study participants were willing to rate some of the statements on their own side of the debate weaker relative to other pro-attitudinal statements, this would indicate that these statements were objectively weaker. As it turned out, significant differences emerged between these strength ratings, allowing for clean categorization (see SI, p. 18).

Figure 8 shows how these statements were rated by those predisposed to disagree with them. Consistent with our theory, the open-mindedness treatment had a roughly equal and significant effect on ratings of weak (Figure 8a) and strong (Figure 8b) counterattitudinal statements. Thus, it appears that, while participants did indeed become more open-minded, this did not necessarily make them more discerning. They were simply seeking to express their open-mindedness. In some cases, this sort of open-mindedness could increase the chance of accepting incorrect information (Kruglanski and Boyatzi 2012), making it less ideal than open-mindedness in service to accuracy motivation. On the other hand, politics need not be viewed as a merely instrumental endeavor in which accurate evaluation aids citizens' efforts to maximize their resources allocations (e.g., Laswell 1936). If we instead think of politics as an opportunity to come together to build consensus and support the common good of the community (e.g., Rousseau 1893), then open-mindedness and consensus-seeking for

[16]Given this asymmetry, we disaggregated our argument strength findings and response time results and found similar patterns. We suspect this asymmetry may be attributable to differences in the relative importance and ideological centrality of gun control in these respective groups. These results are in SI (p. 17).

its own sake might turn out to be quite helpful to the cause of democracy.

Discussion

We began this paper by asking a question with broad implications: What motivates reasoning in the context of politics? We theorized that the answer to this question is conditioned on goals. When a context brings with it the expectation of conflict, as politics does, the natural goal is to "win" the debate by counterarguing against ideas expressed by the other side. But, when the context calls for a person to show open-mindedness, then the goal will be to demonstrate openness to counterattitudinal information.

We conducted three experiments to test this theory. The first examined what people associate with politics and showed that politics primes thoughts of conflict rather than consensus, and closed rather than open-mindedness. Given these associations, we next sought to examine whether the expectation of "politics" would trigger biased reasoning. Using the same methods and measures as Taber and Lodge (2006), we find evidence that motivations are conditioned on the goals salient at the time information is processed. Specifically, we observe that stronger evidence of processing bias among study participants warned that they would be encountering "political" information or potentially disagreeable information compared to the control group, where these labels were removed and biases were muted.

Our third experiment was designed to direct processing motivations in the opposite direction—toward evenhanded evaluation—by telling participants in the treatment condition about a fictitious study linking open-mindedness to life success. As in our second experiment, participants randomly assigned to the control group received no prime in either direction. Again, our methods and measures were based on those used by Taber and Lodge (2006), and again we saw evidence of conditionally motivated reasoning. In this case, however, this motivation was directed toward open-minded evaluation of counterattitudinal statements.

Overall, we believe these results provide strong support for a conditional theory of motivation in politics and have important real-world implications. Utilizing this approach, it becomes clear that bias is not inevitable, and open-minded processing is quite possible to motivate, even in our deeply polarized political landscape (Iyengar et al. 2019). First, to the extent surveys and experiments identify their subject matter as "political," they are likely priming an expectation of conflict, potentially leading to overestimation of bias and polarization. Second, media and politicians likely promote biased reasoning and polarization by talking about substantive policy issues through the lens of conflict and competition between parties and candidates, which becomes associated with politics. Third, institutions that prime expectations of cooperation and coalition-building may motivate individuals to seek consensus through open-minded exchange. Indeed, some suggest that citizens' motivations may differ across electoral systems (Huddy, Bankert, and Davies 2018), in particular those that encourage coalition-building and visible deliberation (Warren and Gastil 2015). Finally, if students are taught, not just that politics is about "who gets what, when, and how" (Laswell 1936) but also deliberation and consensus-building, it might just change the goals made salient by politics.

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Supporting Information

Additional supporting information may be found online in the Supporting Information section at the end of the article.

Appendix A: Study 1 Details
Appendix B: Study 2 Details
Appendix C: Study 2 Analyses
Appendix D: Undergraduate Studies
Appendix E: Study 3 Details
Appendix F: Study 3 Analyses